Extract Four: *These cables date from the summer of 2009, during which time some members of the Haitian parliament were trying to pass a law that would see the minimum wage on the island raised to $5 a day. The cables make it clear that the ambassador shares the perspective of (mainly American) manufacturers based on the island, who were lobbying to keep wages low.*

Created: Jun 10, 2009
SUBJECT: HAITI ANXIOUSLY AWAITS DECISION ON MINIMUM WAGE

1. (SBU) Summary: Parliament's decision to raise daily minimum wages in the commercial and industrial sectors continues to strain relations between President Preval and members of Parliament. Since mid-May, President Preval has encouraged dialogue between members of Parliament and the private sector to spark consideration of a lower or phased-in minimum wage that would allow Haiti to keep jobs, foster greater investment, and defer his responsibility of signing the current minimum wage law. President Preval has yet to sign the law and Parliament is annoyed with Preval's apparent unwillingness to make a clear decision about the increase. A Haitian Association of Industry (ADIH)-funded study indicated that a 200 Haitian gourdes (HTG) per day wage would devastate the textile sector and noted that it could only thrive with a HTG 100 per day minimum wage. Private sector representatives are convinced that members of Parliament understand the impact the increase would have on employment and Haiti's struggling economy. Members of Parliament, however, are adamant that the law be signed as written. No party to the discussion wants to be tainted by appearing to compromise Haitian workers' progress. End Summary.

Parliament Frustrated by Preval's Inaction